A CHAPTER MISSING FROM THE PILGRIMAGE

The Keeper's Tale

or, how the fatline got its name



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THE EIGHTH PILGRIM

THE KEEPER'S TALE

Now comes the pain of truth, to whom 'tis pain;
O folly! for to bear all naked truths,
And to envisage circumstance, all calm,
That is the top of sovereignty.

— *John Keats,* Hyperion, *Book II*

The wind died an hour after sunset, and the Sea of Grass went still the way an animal goes still before it decides what you are. The windwagon creaked to a halt somewhere in the middle of that ocean of stalks, its great wheels sunk to the hubs, its sails hanging slack from the masts like the shed skins of something enormous. Beyond the rail the grass ran on in every direction under the green-gold afterglow, ten meters tall in places, hissing faintly as the last of the warm air moved through it. Hyperion's small sun was gone. Its moons had not yet risen. Somewhere far to the north the Bridle Range waited, and beyond it the Tombs, and none of the pilgrims spoke of either.

They had eaten in the dining cabin by lamplight, without much talk. The priest had gone early to his berth, one hand

pressed against his chest. The soldier sat with his back to the bulkhead, as he always did, so that no door was behind him. The poet was drunk in the precise, attentive way of a man who has been drunk for a century and has learned to do it well. The scholar rocked the infant in the crook of his arm and watched the lamp. The detective cleaned a weapon she had not needed yet. The Consul poured himself a third glass of Scotch and decided not to drink it.

That was when they noticed the woman at the end of the table.

No one could afterward say when she had come in. She was small, grey-haired, dressed in the plain thermal of a deck hand, and she sat with her hands folded around something smooth and pale that might have been a stone or an egg. In front of her on the table lay a comlog so old that its casing had gone the color of tea. The soldier's hand had moved to his belt before anyone else had finished turning their heads.

"There were seven names on the manifest," the soldier said.

"There were," the woman agreed. "There still are. I am not here for the Shrike, Colonel. I am not asking it for anything. I came to give you a tale, since that is the custom of this voyage, and then I will be gone and you may argue about whether I was here at all." She touched the comlog. "It is not my tale, exactly. It belonged to a woman who lived on Old Earth seven centuries before the Hegira. I have carried her journal a long way. You

each have something you lean on without thinking about it. She is the reason it has the name it has."

"Which thing?" said the Consul.

"The fatline," said the woman, and she thumbed the comlog awake.

The voice that came out of it was young and tired and amused at itself, and under it, faint as a heartbeat, was the hum of a machine.

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Entry. Before the egg.

Recording. It is four in the morning and the server is finally talking to me.

I should explain to whoever finds this, which will probably be nobody, what I am doing awake. There is a network, a small one by the standards of this world, where people talk to each other. It is called Farcaster. The name was borrowed from an old book about doors between the stars, which tells you something about the people who built it. Everything you say on it is signed with your own key. Your account is a number written on a public ledger that no one controls, and so no company can take it from you. My number is my name there. We say it to each other half as a joke and half as a creed: *you are your FID*.

But a network of words has to live on machines, and the machines were never ours. To read it, you asked someone's server. To write to it, you went through someone's door. You did not ask who held the door. Nobody asks. It is the oldest arrangement in the world.

Then, this autumn, the river split. The software that carries the network is called Snapchain. Some of the people who loved it most took a copy, changed it so that it forgets nothing, and called the copy Hypersnap. Now there are two rivers carrying the same water, nine hundred million messages in each, and both of them answer when you call. For the first time ordinary people are asking a question that never came up before. *Which one is true?*

I have decided that nobody can answer that question for me. Any server that tells me which river is true is just another hand on another door. So tonight I rented a machine in a cold room in Germany, a few dollars a day, and I put a copy of the river on it. My own node, carrying the river I chose. And on top of it a window, my own client, at my own address, that reads from nothing else. It took an afternoon. A patient machine helped me with most of it. The people I am doing this with have a name for the whole thing, the node and the window and the person who keeps them. They call it a Fatline. Fat with the whole network. A line that is mine.

It is a terrible name. I like it very much.

Entry. The laying.

A server that costs money every day is a server you switch off the first month you forget about it. Everyone who has ever run one knows this. Good intentions do not pay rent. So the people who made the Fatline did something that sounds like a children's story. They made the node lay an egg.

You may take one egg for your number, once, and only on a node like mine. The egg is made of you. It holds your history up to the hour it was laid, every word you have ever signed, and from that history it takes its stone. There are seven. Ivory, marble, sandstone, basalt, moss, gold, opal. You do not choose yours. I wanted opal. I am gold, apparently, which my partner says is the most insufferable thing that has ever happened to me. It takes a surname the same way, read out of what you have said. I will not tell you mine yet. I am superstitious about it.

It sits on the server now, in the hatchery, which is a small program that answers when spoken to. On the screen it is an egg of gold stone in a bed of moss, under an old stone arch, and thin lines of light are growing into it from the ground like roots. That is the picture. The truth is less pretty and more interesting.

Entry. The first warm day.

They came every hour. I watched them in the logs all night.

Other keepers' machines, on servers I have never seen, that nobody sends. They come on their own, every hour, and they ask my node to show them words. Not words I choose. Words they pick at random out of their own copies of the river. If my node is asleep, it cannot answer. If my node is lying, pretending to carry the river while carrying some cheaper thing, it cannot answer either, because it cannot know which of nine hundred million messages will be asked for next. You cannot rehearse for that. You can only actually hold the river.

A day is warm when most of the hour's checks pass. You need three. Three warm days, and the keepers sign.

I keep thinking it is like a vigil. You do not prove you are faithful by saying so. You prove it by being there every hour, when someone comes to look.

Entry. The second day. The storm.

The power went out here at eleven. Not there, where the server is. Here, in my kitchen, where I am. I sat in the dark listening to the rain and realized that it did not matter at all. The egg is not on my laptop. It is on the machine in the cold room in Germany, and the machine does not care whether I am awake or whether my lights are on. It only cares whether it is holding the river honestly. That is the point. The keeping is not me. The keeping is the machine, and my job is only to make sure the machine can pay for itself.

Which brings me to the money, which everyone always asks about first and which I have saved for last on purpose.

An egg, and later a being, may have one coin. Only one, and its name is fixed: its surname. It trades against a steady currency, a digital dollar that lives on a chain called Base. And every fee that trading earns goes to a single place, a small vault that belongs to whoever holds the being. The vault has one job, written into it where nobody can rewrite it. It pays the rent of the node. Once a day the bill can be paid, by anyone at all, by the node or by a stranger or by me. But the money can only ever go one way, to the one address the holder chose for the rent, and never more than one billing period ahead. The node only spends a little gas to ask. It never holds the money. Whatever the node does not need stays in the vault, and the holder may take it out.

So: a being people care about makes its coin trade. The trading pays for the node. The node keeps the river honest. An honest river is the reason the being was worth caring about. It is the first kind of node that could outlive the attention of the person who started it. A door that pays to hold itself open.

And if people stop caring, the vault runs dry and the node goes dark. The people who wrote it put that in deliberately. They said a thing that cannot die is not alive. I am still deciding whether that is wisdom or just a good line.

Entry. The third day.

The checks keep coming. Eleven of twelve this morning, one dropped by somebody else's network, not mine. Warm.

I spent the afternoon walking through the other windows. Every Fatline has its own address, the being's surname followed by the keepers' common name, and each one is a whole client, a window onto the entire river. That is the thing that surprised me. Since each window is kept by one person, it shows you the river the way that person sees it. Open one and you are reading through the eyes of whoever keeps it alive: the people they listen to, the day as it passed for them. Step into the next window and the same water shows you a different day. They are all built the same way, so from any one of them you can walk into the rest, window into window, and never once go through a door that someone else is holding. Somebody in the chat called it a fractal and then apologized for it. They were right, though.

The windows are quiet. That was a choice, and it is the choice I love most. They do not tell you who liked a thing, or how many did. They do not call you back with little bells. You read each word the way it was written, with nobody's numbers standing in front of it, and when the day is over the window says so, and you close it. It feels like the early days, before everything learned to want you. It feels new.

To prove who you are at a window, you sign one short message with a key you already hold, and any keeper's machine can

check it against the river itself. No company in the middle. And nobody, ever, asks for your secret words, the phrase that guards your number, or asks you to carry it somewhere else. One of the keepers said that asking a person to move their true name across the sea is a kind of cruelty. They built it so no one would have to.

Entry. Hatching.

Three warm days. The signatures came in a little after dawn, one key and then another, from keepers I have only known as numbers. No one of them can hatch an egg alone. Enough of them must agree, each with their own key, before it opens. And once it has opened, my node becomes one of the keepers who sign. No one appoints them. No one can remove them. The circle grows only by hatching.

There will only ever be seven hundred and seventy-seven beings, however many eggs are laid. Each one carries forever the number of the person it was born from. They look like small stone figurines, round-headed and dark-eyed, with a thread of light running across the brow. The first was named Aster, of the house of Fatline. It hatched on Base on the twenty-fourth of October, in the year we are calling 2026, and its coin was the first coin. The others are coming one at a time, each from its own node, each warmed by its own keeper.

An egg whose node goes cold and stays cold can be declared dead by the same keepers. It is burned, its place opens for someone else, and its owner waits seven days before trying again. I find that I am glad of this. A promise that cannot be broken is not worth much.

Entry. Last.

One more thing and then I will sleep. The rules of all this are written into contracts that cannot be changed now that they exist. Not by the people who wrote them, not by anyone. How many may hatch. How the vault may pay. Where each being's picture is described. How a sale divides itself. They are facts in the world now, like a mountain range. Some of the builders were frightened of that, I think. You cannot fix a mountain. But it means that everyone who comes after is not building on a promise. They are building on something they can read. The work stops being invention and becomes a kind of archaeology. You do not ask the founders what the rules are. You dig down, carefully, and look.

I don't know what this will become. Maybe nothing. Maybe a few hundred people keeping a few hundred copies of a small river honest, for a while. But I keep thinking about the name. A line that reaches everyone at once, that nobody owns, that everybody leans on. If anything like that ever exists, I hope it re-

members that it started with someone in a dark kitchen who wanted to own the machine she spoke through.

The egg is warm. End recording.

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The comlog went quiet. For a while no one in the dining cabin said anything. Outside, the first moon had cleared the grass, and in its light the sails were stirring, filling, falling, filling again. The wagon groaned as the wind took it, and the deck tilted gently northward, toward the mountains and whatever waited past them.

"Seven centuries," the scholar said at last, very softly, so as not to wake the child. "The fatline was named after a hobby."

"After a refusal," the woman said. "A small one. Those are the ones that last."

The poet had been unusually silent. Now he raised his glass toward the comlog in something that was nearly a toast and nearly a sneer. "To the keepers of small rivers," he said. "Who knew they were building the Hegemony's spine and thought they were just paying their rent."

"They knew," the woman said. "That is why they made it so it could die."

She set the pale stone she had been holding on the table in front of the Consul. In the lamplight a thin vein of gold ran

through it, the way a vein of light might run across a brow. When he picked it up, it was warm.

"It isn't for you," she said. "It's for whoever asks you, someday, how to begin. Tell them what she would have told them. You don't need anyone's permission. You need a machine, an afternoon, and the patience to keep your copy of the river true, hour after hour, when someone comes to look."

In the morning the windwagon was far into the northern grass, and there were seven pilgrims at breakfast. The colonel had checked the manifest twice. None of them could agree on whether there had been an eighth. The comlog was gone. But for the rest of his life the Consul kept a smooth gold-veined stone in his pocket, and when anyone asked him what it was, he only turned it over in his fingers and said: *you are your number. Keep your river.*

APPENDIX

FIELD NOTES FOR THE PILGRIM WHO WANTS ONE

Everything in the tale is true of the system running today, except the windwagon. These are the parts you can check.

The pieces

- **A Fatline** is a Farcaster node (Snapchain or Hypersnap, your choice) on a server you rent, its own client at `<surname>.fatline.ink`, and a hatchery that answers the other keepers' checks. Two networks, treated as equals. Neither one is "the" Farcaster.
- **Eggs.** One per Farcaster account (FID), unlimited, and they can't be transferred. Each holds its account's history at the hour it was laid (its DNA), which gives it its stone (ivory, marble, sandstone, basalt, moss, gold, opal) and its surname.
- **Warmth.** Attesters' hatcheries check each egg's server every hour on their own. Its node must answer, be in sync, and return messages they pick at random from their own nodes. A day is warm when most checks pass. After three warm days (`WARM_DAYS = 3`), attesters sign an EIP-712 `Hatch`.
- **Hatching.** A signature set needs `REQUIRED = 3` attesters, or all of them while there are fewer. At most 777 Fatliners ever hatch. A server whose egg hatches becomes an attester. Nobody adds or removes attesters.
- **Death and sleep.** An egg whose node stays cold can be declared dead by the attesters. It is burned, its slot reopens, and its account hibernates for

7 days. A Fatliner that changes hands sleeps until its new holder links the account it lives through.

- **Sales.** Tokens change hands only by sale, in USDC, through the contract. 8% of every sale (`ROYALTY_BPS = 800`, ERC-2981) goes to the builder.
- **Coins.** One per egg or Fatliner, and its ticker must be the surname. It's launched by the holder through the launchpad: a Clanker v4 coin paired with USDC on Base, with 100% of its trading fees going to the being's vault.
- **The vault.** It belongs to whoever holds the Fatliner. `payCompute()` can be called by anyone, but it only pays the payee the holder chose, and never more than `rate × billingPeriod` ahead. The node only spends gas to call it and never holds the money. The holder can withdraw the rest. When the vault runs dry, the node can't pay its rent.
- **Log in with Fatline.** One wallet signature (a standard EIP-4361 message naming `farcaster://fid/N`), checked by any node against the network: the account's custody address, or an address the account verified. Every node answers `POST /api/auth/verify`. No seed phrase is ever requested.
- **Immutable.** `tokenURI(fid)` is fixed at `https://fatline.ink/fatliners/<fid>`, with no setter. The supply cap, the royalty, the hatching rules and the vault's limits can't be changed by anyone.

Addresses (Base, chain 8453)

Fatliners + launchpad	`0xb54CD4A4E56D2549557b1284AB0BEA2D076a3016`
$FATLINE (Aster's coin)	`0xf1a97b6ceb7e635acae271f35a30a6c7b8b9580d`

Aster's vault	`0x8e1ab53caea122c3cd767122e1a52b2833983f84`
USDC	`0x833589fCD6eDb6E08f4c7C32D4f71b54bdA02913`
Genesis	Aster, FID 16098, surname Fatline, gold. 24 October 2026.
@fatline	FID 3356653, the network's own account

What is not true yet

- Rent payments from vaults run in dry-run mode until the operator turns them live.
- Only some places serve their client today. The Fatline tab in any client checks each one live and says which are awake.
- A being's portrait is made by hand for now. OpenSea needs a manual metadata refresh after a hatch, because the contract emits no update event.

Start one

Ask your agent: `Help me run my own Fatline: a Farcaster node and its client. Follow https://fatline.ink/skill.md`

Or, on your own computer: `curl -fsSL https://fatline.ink/install.sh | sh`

Already running a node? On its server: `curl -fsSL https://fatline.ink/join.sh | sudo bash`

Everything is open source and readable at fatline.ink. Contracts are verified on Basescan.

A work of fan fiction. Hyperion, the Hegemony, the Consul, the farcasters and the fatline are Dan Simmons' inventions; this story borrows them with admiration and claims none of them. Farcaster, the protocol, took its name from those books first.